“…does it matter that a particular insect species is captured by a silken spider web as opposed to a bird’s beak?”

Charles Hawkins and James MacMahon

Broad associations

In the rush to identify guilds, there was some confusion over just what the term meant. By the 1980s, the American ecologists Charles Hawkins and James MacMahon felt the need to redefine the term. They argued that the words “in a similar way” should be dropped from Root’s original definition. It does not matter, they maintained, whether an organism removes a tree leaf to build a nest or for food. It is the resource of the tree leaf that matters rather than the way it is utilized. Either way, the leaf-users belong to a common guild because they are exploiting the same resource.